If a phlebotomist is working outside of their scope of practice, not only is it illegal and could cause significant harm to a patient, but it is also unethical. Ethical behavior requires following a standard of right or wrong conduct to prevent harm to the patient. Several organizations have created a code of ethics for laboratory personnel such as phlebotomists to ensure they are held to the highest standard regarding patient interactions, equipment, specimen collection and processing, and documentation. Phlebotomists have the opportunity to care for a diverse population of patients. This could include patients of various cultures, backgrounds, beliefs, and values. Despite any differences, phlebotomists must be culturally aware and competent. Understanding how beliefs, values, and background might affect how a patient views and understands health, wellness, health care, and medical treatment is necessary. Despite their beliefs or background, every patient deserves to be treated with respect and dignity. Recognizing and appreciating diversity can go a long way in making the patient feel safe and well cared for.

Gender identity and expression are important considerations in any health care setting, including phlebotomy. As a phlebotomy technician, it is essential to create a respectful and inclusive environment for all patients, regardless of their gender identity or expression. Gender identity refers to an individual's internal sense of their own gender, whether male or female, a blend of both, neither, or any other gender. Gender expression is how a person outwardly expresses their gender identity. It can include physical appearance, clothing, hairstyles, behavior, voice, and other forms of presentation. Pronouns are used in everyday language to refer to people, and using the correct pronouns is a way to respect someone's gender identity. Misgendering—using the wrong pronouns or gendered language—can be hurtful, disrespectful, and can negatively impact a patient's health care experience. Some common pronouns include he/him/his, she/her/hers, and they/them/theirs. However, there are many other pronouns that individuals may use.



Workplace Safety

Phlebotomists need to keep both themselves and their patients safe. Safety precautions and policies are implemented to ensure their ability to do this. The National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH) is the federal entity tasked with researching and recommending strategies to prevent injuries and illnesses related to the workplace. As a component of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) within the Department of Health and Human Services (DHHS), NIOSH's primary goal is to generate fresh insights in occupational safety and health and apply this knowledge in practical settings.



A safe work environment is mandated by the Occupational Safety and Health Act and enforced by OSHA. There are general rules in place that must be followed to reduce or even eliminate safety incidents. There are hazards in the lab, including biological, electrical, radiation, and chemical hazards. Safety precautions and rules must be followed to keep everyone safe.

Some examples of general laboratory safety rules set by OSHA include:

- Never eat, drink, chew gum, or put anything in the mouth in the laboratory.
- Never touch the face or eyes while in the laboratory.
- Always wear a lab coat and ensure it remains fully buttoned.
- Remove the lab coat when leaving the lab. Do not wear it to lunch, on break, or home.
- Nails should be kept short with no nail polish or artificial nails.
- Ensure footwear is made of non-permeable material, closed-toe, and not clog-style.

TABLE 2.1 Hazards

TYPE OF HAZARD	EXAMPLE
Biological	Biological fluids or specimens such as blood, tissue, or other body fluids
Electrical	Electrical shock and fire from equipment that is not working or not used correctly
Radiation	Drawing blood from a patient receiving radiation therapy
Chemical	Hazardous chemicals such as chemicals used for cleaning or preservatives used for lab tests

Fire Extinguishers

To properly operate a fire extinguisher, remember **PASS**.

P: Pull the pin.

A: Aim the nozzle.

S: Squeeze the trigger.

S: Sweep the nozzle at the base of the fire.